

EXT. PARK BENCH - SUNRISE

A man, MAN, is sitting on a bench. A notepad lies on his lap. He is ignoring the sunrise. He takes a deep breath and picks up his pen, ready to write.

MAN (v.o.)

Chère Maman... Tu me manques. (Dear Mom... I miss you.)

MAN softly shakes his head and scratches out the words. He takes another soft breath and starts writing again.

MAN (v.o.)

Chère Maman... J'ai commencé à réfléchir au progrès... Je repensais à notre dernière conversation... Et cela m'a rappelé notre voyage en train de Toulouse à... je ne sais plus où... (Dear Mom... I have started thinking about progress... I was thinking about our last conversation... And it reminded me of our train ride from Toulouse to... I can't remember where...)

MAN softly shakes his head again and scratches out the words. He takes another soft breath and starts writing again.

MAN (v.o.)

Maman... Je repensais à notre dernière conversation... Que voulais-tu dire quand tu as dit : « (Mom... I was thinking about our last conversation... What did you mean when you said, ")

Man struggles to remember the word. Beckon... How does that translate?

WOMAN (o.s.)

Appeler...

MAN does not notice/acknowledge the voice. He continues writing.

MAN

(Beckon sentence in English)

WOMAN (o.s.)

Appeler...

MAN slowly looks around at Nature, searching for the source. Is it his mother? The wind? He goes back to writing.

MAN
(Beckon sentence in
English)

WOMAN (o.s.)
Appeler...

MAN remembers the word. He begins writing.

A WOMAN, 30s, is sitting on a parallel bench across the
lookout.

MAN (v.o.)
(Says the BECKON sentence
in French)

WOMAN
(softly)
Come here often?

MAN
(surprised)
Huh?

WOMAN
(louder)
Do you come here often?

MAN
Ah... yes. In the mornings, you?

WOMAN
(smiles)
Wouldn't you know if you come here
often?

MAN
(smiles back)
Not with certainty.

WOMAN
(pauses)
Passing through. Duluth. Keokuck.
Now... As good a stop as any,
wouldn't you say?

MAN
Why?

WOMAN gestures towards the landscape with her eyes.

MAN
Why are you passing through?

WOMAN prepares for a big anecdote.

MAN
(cuts her off)
What are you reading?

WOMAN
Oh, Pushkin.

WOMAN holds up the book. It's a worn copy of Eugene Onegin.

MAN
In Russian?

WOMAN
No, translation.

MAN
Oh.

MAN returns to his notebook. WOMAN slowly pulls out a folded map.

WOMAN
Would you happen to know the way out?

MAN
Straight down. Take a right at the sycamore by the bend. Then you'll hit the main road.

WOMAN
What does a sycamore look like?

MAN
If you have gone too far, you'll know.

MAN closes his notebook, stands up. He takes a few steps forward, then lights a cigarette.

WOMAN folds her map and returns to her book.

WOMAN
(while reading)
It's not all translatable, you know.
But how else would we know of Pushkin?

MAN
(defeated)
Hmm... Feeble meaning is still better than nothing at all.

A gust of wind blows through the trees. MAN and WOMAN are taken by surprise.

WOMAN
Is it a poem?

MAN
Something like that. (Laughs) It
doesn't rhyme.

WOMAN stands up and takes a few steps. She looks into the distance.

A stronger gust of wind blows through. MAN's sheet of paper flies away. It twists and turns in the air. MAN chases the paper.

WOMAN
Hah... He has a very rebellious turn
of mind...

Slowly, WOMAN begins following MAN. MAN picks up the fallen paper.

2 EXT. WOODS - DAYTIME

2

A young BOY, 7, picks up some soil. He hears his name and turns towards its source.

Slowly, he walks towards it. Is he being pulled or is he searching?

3 EXT. PARK ROAD - MOMENTS LATER

3

MAN and WOMAN are walking on the road.

WOMAN
(comfortable)
On my way up from Ste. Genevieve,
train got delayed...because of
another train.... Man behind me gets
a call from his wife.... She's angry
because surely he is cheating
again... Hah...

MAN
You said you came from Keokuck...

WOMAN
I misspoke...

They walk in silence for a beat.

WOMAN (cont.)
The train stops half a mile too far.
He passes her house on the
train...to get to her house...

MAN
Feels like fate, no?

WOMAN
I am indifferent to fate.

MAN
A half-mile walk isn't too far, if
it takes you home.

WOMAN (cont.)
Every time I go home, this tiredness
overcomes me...

MAN and WOMAN look up. They notice a small beauty. (A
tree, a bird...)

4 EXT. WOODS - MOMENTS LATER

4

The BOY continues navigating through the woods. He cuts
through bushes and trees. He arrives at an opening.

WOMAN (v.o.)
It's so beautiful that you think you
discovered it...

MAN (v.o.)
And if we didn't?

WOMAN (v.o.)
But, it feels like the beginning of
a process, rather than an end in
itself...

MAN (v.o.)
Oh, beauty...

A moment of silence.

MAN (v.o.)
The blindness to which it gave
rise... If only we could see.

WOMAN (v.o.)
What would we see?

MAN (v.o.)
We would see straight away that
something is true, and something is
false.

5 EXT. BOLLARD AREA - MOMENTS LATER

5

MAN and WOMAN are weaving through the bollards.

MAN
Cigarette?

WOMAN
No...

Man lights one more cigarette for himself.

MAN
When do you leave?

WOMAN
Soon.

MAN
Stay another day. See the city.

WOMAN
No...

MAN
What's the hurry?

MAN and WOMAN sit on bollards.

WOMAN
Time... Maybe on a cooler, quieter
day, I would have said yes...

MAN blows into the air. You can see his breath... WOMAN
smiles.

MAN
It takes two sunrises to know this
town...

WOMAN
L'avenir nous prend les bras...or
something. (L'avenir nous tend les
bras.)

MAN
You can't disappear...

WOMAN
I can't disappear. I'm to be wed in
a month. Some altar requires my
presence.

MAN
Oh, congratulations. Where's your—

WOMAN
Guatemala.

MAN
What for?

WOMAN
Digging wells.

MAN
Oh, commendable.

WOMAN

It's what drew me to him.

MAN

And how do you manage the separation?

MAN and WOMAN move to closer bollards.

WOMAN

I don't think about that. [Pauses]
To remember one thing while
excluding everything else is a
separation in itself.

MAN

Still it must be...

WOMAN

From time to time... and from time
to time he sends me photos of water
systems and children with strange
shaped hats.

MAN gets up and walks away. WOMAN follows.

MAN

But you're creating different
memories...

WOMAN

All memories are an invention of
Repression.

They walk in silence.

WOMAN

Human consciousness is oriented
toward what hasn't arrived... You
cannot live without daydreaming...

MAN

I think there is another way...

WOMAN

It's easier to. Because to not means
to die. And it's never easy to die.

MAN

You cannot live without memory...
It's never easy to die.

WOMAN

The heart's memory eliminates the
bad and magnifies the good. The
mind's is quite the opposite. Either
(MORE)

WOMAN (CONT'D)
way, it's catering to first world
issues through a first world lens...

MAN
Tell me more.

WOMAN
The past. It's a Bourgeois
self-interest... And it likes to
draw all other interest into its own
failure...

MAN
Bourgeois?

MAN looks down at his clothes.

WOMAN
My words poorly portray my
thoughts...

MAN
Everything first sneaks in through
language. Action comes later... Read
me from your book.

WOMAN reads from book.

MAN
I doubt you ever even notice when
the skies change from day to
night...

WOMAN
Hah... How can you tell?

MAN
The way you read...

WOMAN puts the book in her jacket pocket...

MAN
A beautiful jacket...

WOMAN
It was my mother's...

MAN
It reeks of genealogy...

MAN (cont.)
The best color for a jacket...and
for the leaves...

MAN walks away.

6 EXT. WOODS - CONTINUOUS**6**

BOY walks through the opening, and sees a bed/manger in the middle of the woods.

He slowly makes his way up to it. He touches the cloth. He slowly gets on. He starts jumping. Slow, then faster.

He starts to turn. Suddenly, he stops. He sees something. Tears well in his eyes.

7 EXT. LOVER'S LEAP - MOMENTS LATER**7**

MAN and WOMAN are sitting on a ledge. WOMAN reads from her book. She pauses.

WOMAN

So you hate translations?

MAN:

I don't hate them. In fact, I succumb to them.

WOMAN

But nothing is ever transmitted in its entirety. Always a filtered remainder.

MAN

Ah, so preservation?

WOMAN

something

MAN

Language itself is a filtering of its own.

WOMAN

Language is just a mode of communication.

MAN

Yes, but not poetry. [Pause] Communication transmits what is already known. But what about the unknown? [Pauses] What about the moment when something within the human being becomes too complete, too charged, too coherent to remain unexpressed... and therefore must take shape in the world.

WOMAN

As in... a becoming?

MAN pauses.

MAN

The Poem doesn't tell you that something is being felt; it makes you feel that something was felt. Expression is its arrival. Not its becoming.

WOMAN

Beauty is futural in action.

MAN

It is elegaic in substance.

They pause.

MAN

So can it be received? Or perceived?

WOMAN

Something beautiful isn't a prisoner of perception. It's the master of it.

MAN

As in reorientation?

WOMAN

Yes, and in that sense, beauty is simply presence.

MAN

And what about the presence of absence? I find that incredibly beautiful.

WOMAN

You must have your reasons.

MAN chuckles.

WOMAN

Some want time measured out. Some want it felt.

They sit in silence.

The river, trees, skies, open field, are all listening in. MAN and WOMAN are one with nature.

WOMAN

How old are the trees? The river?

MAN

And the wind?

WOMAN

It's hard to say.

MAN
It's hard to know.

8 **EXT. WOODS - CONTINUOUS**

WOMAN, now old, stands in the forest. She looks somberly
into the distance.

8